

A sticky end

Thirty-eight thousand years ago, a pack of saber-toothed cats were pursuing a weak mammoth. The mammoth stumbled into what it thought was a shallow pool, and found itself trapped in sticky tar. The cats were soon trapped, too. Hunted and hunters died. They had fallen into a massive tar pit.

LA BREA

Thousands of fossilized animal bones have been found at the La Brea Tar Pits in Los Angeles, many dating back to the last ice age. There are also huge quantities of fossilized plants and insects—altogether these pits have provided a fascinating view of life in the Los Angeles area some 38,000 years ago.



DID YOU KNOW?

A tar pit is more correctly known as an asphalt pit (asphalt is naturally occurring, whereas tar is made by people). It is a place where asphalt leaks to the ground's surface. Asphalt pits have proved valuable in studying ecosystems that existed thousands of years ago because of the animals caught and preserved in them.



Many of the species found at La Brea are still there today, including the California condor.

